

AI Usage Reflection — Detroit Storyworks

JavaScript 102 | September 2026

I used ChatGPT as my AI coding partner for Detroit Storyworks. My original vision was to make the site feel clearly connected to Detroit without turning it into a generic tourism page. I wanted an industrial, energetic visual direction influenced by Detroit manufacturing and music, while keeping the website simple enough to finish, test, and explain.

ChatGPT helped me break the assignment into the required pieces, choose a beginner-friendly API, plan the HTML structure, create the CSS layout, and write the JavaScript interactions. We chose the Wikipedia/MediaWiki API because it does not require a private API key and can return useful information about Detroit landmarks, musicians, neighborhoods, and cultural movements. The main feature lets a visitor search for a Detroit subject and displays live information on the page. ChatGPT also helped with the loading state, response-status check, no-results state, try/catch error handling, experience filters, and inquiry-form validation.

The main communication challenge was scope. I did not want an advanced or over-engineered project, because I needed to understand the code and meet the assignment requirements efficiently. I made that priority clear, and we kept the final feature set small: one API discovery feature, one category filter, and one inquiry form. I rejected adding unnecessary frameworks, authentication, maps, or complicated visual effects because they would add work without improving the required learning goals.

I understand `async/await` and `fetch` better after this build. The `async` function waits for `fetch` to return a `Response`, checks `response.ok`, converts the response to JSON, and then uses the returned data to update the DOM. The `try/catch` block gives the user a useful message when the request fails instead of leaving the result area blank.